



Sierra Leone

The west African state of Sierra Leone achieved independence from the UK in 1961. Today, trying to recover from ten years of devastating civil war, it is one of the world's poorest nations.



GEOGRAPHY

Flat plain, running the length of the coast, stretches inland for 83 miles (133 km). Beyond, forests rise to highlands near neighboring Guinea in the northeast.



CLIMATE

Hot tropical weather, with very high rainfall and humidity. The dusty, northeastern *harmattan* wind blows November–April.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Mende and Temne are the major ethnic groups. Freetown's citizens are largely descended from slaves freed from Britain and the US, resulting in a strongly Anglicized Creole culture in the capital. The countryside is less developed. A brutal civil war broke out in 1991 and was not properly resolved until a 2001 peace agreement. Two million people were displaced during the conflict.



THE ECONOMY

Aid is vital: reconstruction will take years. Diamond exports, though smuggling is rife. Rutile and bauxite also mined. Coffee and cocoa are cash crops, but most farming is subsistence.



INSIGHT: *The British philanthropist Granville Sharp set up a settlement for freed slaves in Freetown in 1787*



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of Sierra Leone

DATE OF FORMATION: 1961

CAPITAL: Freetown

POPULATION: 5.7 million

TOTAL AREA: 27,698 sq. miles
(71,740 sq. km)

DENSITY: 206 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Mende, Temne, Krio, English*

RELIGIONS: Muslim 30%, traditional beliefs 30%, other 30%, Christian 10%

ETHNIC MIX: Mende 35%, Temne 32%, other 21%, Limba 8%, Kuranko 4%

GOVERNMENT: Presidential system

CURRENCY: Leone = 100 cents